

Cloud handoff — #486, the "tips unknown" admission is folded away and counted as a ref

Written: 2026-08-25 · **By:** max (CLI session on Tom's box) · **For:** a cloud Claude Code session on `tom2025b/git-vista`

The smallest of the six, and the one where the previous session did most of your work for you. The defect is measured, the fix is named, and there is already a `# [should_panic]` test in the tree whose assertions are correct and waiting. Read it before you write anything of your own.

```
task_id: gv-486-tips-unknown-fold
issue: 486
milestone: – # a #329 successor
repo: tom2025b/git-vista
base: main
branch: fix/486-tips-unknown-not-folded
sign_commits_as:
  name: Claude_Max
  email: 262510778+tom2025b@users.noreply.github.com
sign_artifacts_as: max
adr_number: 0081 # ASSIGNED. Do not pick "the next free" c
allowed_paths:
  - crates/git-vista-core/src/activity.rs
  - crates/git-vista-server/src/planner/fetch.rs # only if the st
  - docs/adr/
forbidden_paths:
  - design-docs/
  - ci/browser/**
  - crates/git-vista/src/**
  - handoff.md
merge_order: independent – nothing else in this batch touches activ
```

The defect, already measured

`journal_unobserved` (`planner/fetch.rs:542`) fires when `git fetch` **succeeded** and only the re-read of `refs/remotes/<remote>/*` failed. It journals one entry with `ref_name: None` and both oids `Obs::Unknown`:

"fetched from 'origin', but refs/remotes/origin could not be re-read afterwards, so which remote-tracking refs moved is unknown: ..."

If the fetch succeeded it very likely moved refs — and git wrote a reflog line for every one. The admission carries no `new_oid`, so it matches no reflog line in `assemble_feed`'s attribution step and **suppresses none of them**. They all survive, the admission joins them, and `fold_ref_update_bursts` folds the lot together:

```
journal:  1 × "fetched from 'origin' ... (tips unknown – git could not  
reflog:   4 × "fetch origin: fast-forward"  
feed:     1 × "fetch – 5 refs updated"
```

Two harms in one line of output. The deliberate admission is replaced by a confident count — the exact distinction `Obs::Unknown` rather than `Obs::Absent` exists to preserve, destroyed in the direction of false confidence. And the count is wrong anyway: four refs moved, and the admission is itself counted as the fifth.

What is already in the tree, and must not be re-derived

`crates/git-vista-core/src/activity.rs` carries all of this, written by the session that found it:

- **The corrected doc comment**, lines ~605-620. The comment *used* to claim the entry was safe because it is journaled "instead of per-ref entries, never alongside them, so it is always a run of one". That reasoning accounts for the journal and forgets git's reflog — **the same shape of mistake that got the first #329 attempt reverted in `0a7ba777`**. The comment now says so.
- **A `#[should_panic]` test at ~line 1284**, documented as *F2*, whose doc comment names the fix outright:

Fixing this: exclude it from folding. `ref_name: None` with both oids `None` is the shape `journal_unobserved` alone produces. Then delete the `#[should_panic]` — the assertions below are already right.

Read that test's assertions before writing any of your own, and do not rewrite them to fit your implementation. They were written by someone who had measured the failure. If your fix cannot satisfy them as they stand, your fix is the thing to change.

Full evidence: `docs/investigations/2026-08-25-issue-329-fetch-feed-volume.md`.

The one thing to be careful about

The named fix — exclude `ref_name: None` with both oids `None` from folding — is almost certainly right. **Check it is not too wide before you ship it.** Is `journal_unobserved` genuinely the only producer of that shape? If some other path also emits an entry with no ref name and no oids, excluding the shape excludes those too, and a burst that *should* fold stops folding.

Grep for every construction site of that shape rather than trusting the comment — that trust is precisely what produced the defect you are fixing. If the shape turns out to be shared, say so and propose a narrower discriminator (an explicit marker on the entry, for instance) in **ADR 0081** rather than widening the exclusion quietly.

The comment's original claim, by the way, **is** true in exactly one case: a fetch that moved nothing at all, which is the one case with no reflog lines. A fix that keeps folding correct there as well is the complete one.

What you cannot run

The browser leg does not run in a cloud container — the kernel reports `landlock_abi=-1` and INV-13 gives the server no degraded tier; installing `bwrap` changes nothing. This is a pure-core change and should not need it. If you find yourself wanting a browser assertion, the change has reached the frontend, which is outside `allowed_paths` — stop and say so in the PR.

`cargo test -p git-vista-core` and `cargo test --workspace` are yours and must be green. Two tests in `git-vista-server` flake under parallel execution because they race on the process-global current repository (#438):

`recovery_center::tests::a_stale_claimed_undo_is_refused_and_the_branch_is_left_alone` and

`state::tests::selection_flow_carries_mode_and_gates_writes`. Re-run before believing either is your doing.

Acceptance

1. Four refs moved with the re-read failing renders as **the admission, intact** — not "5 refs updated", and not "4 refs updated" either. The user must see that something could not be read.
2. The `#[should_panic]` on the F2 test is **deleted** and the test passes on its own assertions, unedited.
3. A fetch that moved nothing at all still folds as it did before. Add the test if one does not exist — the doc comment says this is the case the original claim was true for, so it is the case a too-wide fix breaks.
4. Every test pinning this is proved able to go red **two different ways** — remove the exclusion, and weaken it (exclude on `ref_name: None` alone, say). One `caught` verdict is not proof; a

Git-Vista test survived one mutation and caught another on 2026-08-22, and either alone gives the wrong verdict.

5. **ADR 0081** records the discriminator chosen and why — especially if the grep above found the shape is shared.

`docs/adr/README.md` index updated.

5. `cargo fmt --all`, `cargo clippy --all-targets -- -D warnings`, `cargo test --workspace` green.

7. PR body says Closes #486. **Never delete the branch.**

Signed: max · 2026-08-25T07:24:00-04:00